



Teams

For Your 360-Degree Feedback to Be Effective, You Need to Discuss It

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Summary. 360-degree feedback alone does not improve leadership effectiveness. Meaningful change will only happen if you engage directly with your colleagues to learn more about what you could do better. How do you have these conversations? Start by expressing... [more](#)

A senior leader I coached was on the verge of quitting after receiving his 360-degree review. For most of his career, he'd been praised and promoted for having a strong voice, challenging others, and "breaking things" so the organization could rebuild better.

But the most recent feedback from his boss and peers suggested that he wasn't working effectively as a team player in the executive group. Initially hurt and angry, he eventually mustered the courage to speak directly to his colleagues about what they'd collectively shared in the 360, even if the anonymity of the process kept him from knowing who exactly had said what. Through these interactions, he discovered that he had far more support than he realized. His fellow executives weren't resisting his ideas or the changes he wanted to make; they simply wanted him to be less oppositional and more collaborative.

Once they talked openly, his peers aligned around his suggested transformation, and he gained momentum and credibility.

The 360 itself didn't change anything. The follow-up conversations were what made the difference. Indeed, [research](#) shows that the biggest predictor of increased leadership effectiveness after a 360 is whether you discussed the feedback with the people who gave it to you. So how do you do that effectively? The following strategies can help.

Start with gratitude.

Before you do anything else, thank the people who took the time to give you feedback. When you express genuine appreciation, you signal that you value their perspective and that you're taking the process seriously.

Be sincere and specific: "I appreciate the thoughtfulness everyone put into this. Although the feedback is anonymous, I learned what people appreciate about me and where I can continue to improve."

For example, one leader I know confessed to his direct reports that their positive comments about the support he'd given them through cutbacks and restructuring nearly brought him to tears. He then acknowledged that he also valued their constructive feedback on a few other things that he could be doing better.

Once you have shown your appreciation, let people know you'll share more specific takeaways once you've had time to process: "I'll come back to you later to talk about some things I want to work on in each area and ask for your help." This sets the stage for deeper conversations to come.

Move from assumptions to conversations.

When you read your 360 report, you'll naturally draw assumptions about what people meant. But the worst thing you can do is stay in your own head, interpreting feedback through your own lens and never testing whether you got it right.

Take Michelle, a senior leader preparing for a future C-suite role, whose 360 indicated that people questioned her decision-making ability. Because she's a reflective leader, she assumed the issue was speed, so she pushed herself to make faster choices. But this felt stressful, chaotic, and unsustainable.

When she finally opened a dialogue with her team, she learned her teammates weren't frustrated with the pace of her decision-making. They were upset about the lack of transparency in her process. When was she gathering input? When could they influence the outcome? When would the final decision be made?

Armed with these insights, she began to better communicate how she would operate with the involvement of others.

It's critical to test your assumptions with colleagues. If not, you may be focusing your attention in the wrong direction.

Structure your conversations thoughtfully.

The next step is to schedule meetings with your direct reports (as a group or one-on-one), your peers (individually), and your boss or bosses. Let them know what you want to talk about so they can prepare. The goal is simple: Explore the feedback with curiosity.

When you sit down with these stakeholders, you'll want to focus on five things.

Share your takeaways first.

Start by naming what you read: "Here are the things that people seem to really appreciate about me" and "Here are the things I heard people saying I could do differently to be more effective. This shows you've done the work of reflection and that you're ready to learn.

Invite exploration, not justification.

Instead of asking "Why was I rated this way?" (which puts people on the defensive) try questions like: "People seem to see me in this way. Can you help me understand what they may be noticing?" Or "Could you give me an example of when you've experienced that?" Or "Do you think this happens often, or only in certain situations?"

These questions are open-ended and genuinely curious. They invite the other person to share their perspective without feeling like they need to defend the feedback.

Focus on impact, not intention.

Ask questions like "What impact does this behavior have?" and "In what situations would it be most important for me to be aware of this?" These help you understand the real-world consequences of your actions, even if your intentions were good.

Listen without committing.

Your objective is to gather data, not to defend yourself or make promises. Tell people: “I’m exploring and trying to learn more. I’ll come back to you once I’ve thought through what changes I want to focus on.”

This reduces pressure on both sides. You have time to think before deciding what to change. Your stakeholders can be honest because they’re not waiting for you to react or commit to immediate fixes.

Watch out for defensiveness.

If you find yourself explaining or justifying (“That wasn’t my intention” or “But here’s what was really happening”), stop. When you get defensive, people shut down.

Prepare neutral responses in advance: “Thank you for sharing,” or “That’s helpful to understand. Could you give me an example?” These responses keep the conversation open.

Remember that some of the most valuable insights will be the hardest to hear. If you are hurt or angry, acknowledge your feelings privately but set them aside before you meet with the person. Resist the urge to argue with the feedback or prove it wrong.

Build momentum through ongoing dialogue.

After you’ve had these initial conversations, follow up with your stakeholders. Pick one or two behaviors to work on improving, share those ambitions with your colleagues, and ask them to watch for progress. Be transparent about what you’re immediately addressing and what you’re not. You can’t change everything at once.

I coached a leader named David whose 360 revealed that his team felt unappreciated, feedback that caught him completely off

guard, since he'd always considered himself to be a caring and grateful boss. Through conversations, he discovered the real issue: His quiet style meant he rarely highlighted his employees' accomplishments beyond the team itself.

Once David understood this, he began broadcasting their achievements more widely across the organization. He then checked back in: "I've been working on making your contributions more visible to senior leadership. Are you seeing a difference?" He also asked a trusted peer on the executive team: "Have you noticed a shift in how I'm communicating about their work? Is this having an impact?" These follow-up conversations allowed him to refine his approach.

Your willingness to continue seeking feedback is critical to your growth.

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The purpose of 360 feedback isn't to "fix" you. It's to expand your awareness and give you more choices about how you lead.

When you invite others into the process through genuine conversation, you strengthen trust and collaboration across your team. You signal that you value input and that you're committed to growth. The 360 report is just the beginning. The real work happens in what you do next.



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